

did not notice Prakash who was close by, overhearing his end of the conversation.

‘If you are looking to buy Dr Reddy’s, I have a much better rate for you . . . oh . . . not interested . . . well, okay . . . sorry . . . no, but I thought . . . okay . . . I am really sorry,’ said Owl, keeping the receiver down. A similar conversation followed on his next call. It had not occurred to Owl that I had played a trick on him.

Two days later I did something similar. This time, realization dawned on Owl that I could be misleading him. He must have reported everything to his masters, for soon one more person was assigned to tail me. This time I dialled four brokers at random before placing the right call.

Owl and the other spy seemed to have had enough of the abuses that came their way from calling the wrong brokers. The AS-PS clique left me in peace after that.

Or rather, I thought so. But I was mistaken. Outwardly, their hostility towards me ceased somewhat, and once in a while even the usually gruff PS would greet me with a smile in the ring. I felt the past was forgiven and forgotten. Little did I know that the duo was patiently waiting for an opportunity to get back at me. And, one day, I myself gifted them the chance they had been looking for.

It was a fairly busy noon when Owl walked up to me inquiring about the rates I was offering for Apollo Tyres. We had dealt with each other a few times after the hotline snooping affair, and things had gone off smoothly. I had no reason to suspect anything. I quoted my rate; Owl said he wanted to sell 500 shares. I bought them off him. He asked the rate for another 500, and I gave him the same quote. He then said he wanted to sell some more. I instinctively felt Owl was trying to pull a fast one on me. I quoted a lousy rate so that he would walk away, but to my surprise he sold me another 500 shares, and asked for still another quote. I quoted an even lousier rate, increasing the spread sharply so that it looked obvious that I was trying to blatantly overcharge him.

I was expecting him to make some scathing remarks and walk away in a huff. But he again surprised me.

‘Arre Lala, you are trying to kill me by quoting such rates,’ he whined.

‘It is up to you whether you want to take it or not,’ I said disdainfully.

‘You have become a big man, Lala, but that does not give you the right to treat small jobbers like me with contempt,’ he protested.